Daniel Hardesty Lewis

Research Engineer

Specializing in causal inference, automated validation, and scalable distributed infrastructure. Delivered forecasting, financial modeling, and statewide resiliency platforms across geospatial & time-series workloads.

Core Expertise

8 years **ML Engineering**: Build and operate AI/ML training and inference pipelines, using rigorous validation protocols to ensure model generalization and reliability

8 years **Backend & Data**: Build schemas and ETL; ship API-backed services using Python, SQL, and Postgres/PostGIS

8 years **Distributed Systems**: Scale batch workloads across distributed systems, profile bottlenecks, and optimize latency & throughput with explicit cost-performance tradeoffs

10 years **Geospatial AI**: Spatiotemporal modeling for risk, planning, and hazard decision-support use cases

8 years **Technical Leadership**: Drive cross-functional execution via specifications and governance; mentor engineers through design reviews, code reviews, and instruction

Technologies

Causal AI	DoWhy; EconML; PyWhy; CausalNex; Double ML; Causal Forests
Modeling	PyTorch; TensorFlow; scikit-learn; Transformers; LoRA/QLoRA/PEFT
LLM apps	embeddings; RAG; LangChain; LangGraph; DSPy; FAISS
Data stack	Python; SQL; Pandas; Polars; PyArrow; Parquet; Postgres; PostGIS; Redis; Elasticsearch; Supabase
Infrastructure	Linux/Unix; Bash; Git; Docker; Kubernetes; Modal; GCS; Ray; Spark; Dask; Airflow; CI/CD; observability
Additional	CUDA; C++; TypeScript; React

Experience

Professional

Dec. 2025 – Present **Founder**, *Worldcastr*, New York, NY
Spatiotemporal foundation model of the real world, and the platform that puts it behind high-stakes decisions: one model from the individual parcel or condo unit to the nation, and from days to decades.
- Built a parcel-scale diffusion forecaster on 50M+ parcel-year observations: 7.0% one-year error, competitive with Zillow's valuation accuracy on a harder forward-looking task; 12.6% MdAE at 4 years, NYC.
- Engineered spatial inducing tokens, per-horizon loss normalization, and DDIM sampling; validated forecast reliability via PIT uniformity, interval coverage, and sharpness diagnostics before web delivery.
- Built an LLM chat engine with 30+ function-calling tools over geographic data and comparables, with dual-model routing between Claude and GPT-4o Mini optimized for cost and latency.
- Owned the pipeline from data ingestion to real-time serving through the first product, Homecastr (roughly 14M production requests weekly); refined product strategy through direct feedback from a16z and MetaProp.

Jun. 2026 – Sep. 2026 **Member**, *South Park Commons*, New York, NY
Selective technology community for founders at a leading venture capital firm.
- Designed and implemented the next iteration of the Worldcastr machine learning architecture: a full-sequence inpainting editable world model.
- Conducted customer discovery with potential ICPs, including Parcl, Crusoe, and Cushman & Wakefield, to align predictive capabilities with enterprise requirements.

Oct. 2024 – Sep. 2025 **Technical Advisor**, *PoliBOM*, Seattle, WA
AI tariff mitigation and trade compliance product for manufacturers, centered on agentic BOM analysis and policy scenario simulation.
- Engineered an agentic retrieval-augmented pipeline for BOM parsing and tariff simulation, replacing manual trade-compliance analysis with predictable multi-step reasoning.
- Directed development of a **conversational AI interface** enabling decision-makers to instantly **retrieve BOMs and receive proactive compliance alerts**.
- Executing customer discovery with ScoutyAI and Columbia economists, and secured early market validation by presenting the prototype to KPMG.

Nov. 2023 – Aug. 2025 **Founder**, *Summit Geospatial*, New York, NY
High-resolution elevation data and web delivery for engineering and hazard analysis.
- Engineered a **statewide seamless Texas DEM mosaic**, resampling 0.5 m LiDAR sources to 1.2 m via nearest-neighbor across **70+ state, federal, and local elevation datasets**.
- Developed the web distribution platform end-to-end including **data pipeline, tiling, hosting, delivery UX** to support engineering and planning use cases.

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Aug. 2021 – Aug. 2023 **Senior Data Scientist & Technical Lead**, *Texas Advanced Computing Center (TACC)*, Austin, TX

- Spun out Summit Geospatial alongside UT's VPs of IP to commercialize state-level terrain models from the $40M Texas Disaster Information System (TDIS), delivering precision decision-support for civil engineering.
- Developed inter-agency RFP and MOU frameworks with state and federal partners, translating technical requirements into scope and milestones facilitating Real-Time Inundation Mapping and TDIS.
- Scaled climate and flood models through **1M-node-scale jobs** on **Frontera, a top-5 most powerful supercomputer in the world**; managed $1M+ compute budgets and NOAA, NSF, USACE, and GLO partnerships.
- Developed efficient methods to produce high-resolution 1m flood maps from National Water Model outputs for Texas Emergency Management's Real-Time Inundation Mapping.
- Partnered with the US Army Corps of Engineers to statistically model compound flood hazards in coastal Texas, integrating high-resolution topographic data with hydrological models.
- Contributed research supporting Paola Passalacqua's 2022 EGU Bagnold Medal, one of geomorphology's highest honors.
- Served as Technical Reviewer for Frontera Doctoral Fellows (2023) and Large-Scale Computing Pathways (2022) applications, evaluating $10M+ in computing resource allocations on one of the world's largest supercomputers.

Feb. 2018 – Jul. 2021 **Data Scientist & Research Engineer**, *Texas Advanced Computing Center (TACC)*, Austin, TX

- Competed in DARPA World Modelers to improve disaster resiliency and food security modeling in East Africa.
- Mentored Petrobras engineers in deep learning and HPC to enable institutional technology transfer.
- Cited by AAAI President Yolanda Gil in her farewell address for contributions to automated scientific modeling.

Research

Sep. 2024 – May 2026 **Graduate Thesis Researcher**, *Columbia University GSAPP*, New York, NY

- Formulated **S-IRM** and **I-DML** (Invariant DML with ICP pre-filtering) to extract environment-invariant causal features and eliminate spatial wealth confounder bias.
- Designed an **Adversarial Causal Spatial Autoencoder** (PyTorch) using minimax gradient reversal to disentangle spatial opposition geometry from neighborhood wealth.

May 2025 – Aug. 2025 **Research assistant to Dir. Electrical Engineering Zoran Kostic**, *Columbia University*, New York, NY

- Math benchmarking and finetuning of Deepseek's GRPO algorithm

Jan. 2025 – Oct. 2025 **Research assistant to Dir. Financial Engineering Ali Hirsa (Industry-sponsored research)**, *Columbia University*, New York, NY

- Developed a multi-asset CVAE latent factor model with Skew-T Mixture priors; achieved 85% R^2 vs. commercial SaaS (75%) and Fama-French (58%) on backtested holdout.
- Derived a tractable, axiom-compliant per-feature SHAP algorithm using Hessian-based recursive clustering to provide stable temporal regime-dependent attributions for deep learning models.

July 2019 – Aug. 2019 **Summer research intern to Pres. AAAI Yolanda Gil**, *University of Southern California*, Los Angeles, CA

- Integrated hydrological models into the MINT Platform, competing year-long with MITRE to provide DARPA the "Airflow for science"

Teaching

Jan. 2018 – Dec. 2020 **Co-instructor**, *The University of Texas at Austin*, Austin, TX
Helped design and teach graduate-level courses: *Machine Learning for the Geosciences* for Petrobras engineers, *Intelligent Systems for the Geosciences*, and *Scientific Computation*.

Select Publications

2026 **Hardesty Lewis, D.**, "Predicting Formal Protest Petitions Against Housing Development: Evidence from Austin, Texas". M.S. Thesis, Columbia University GSAPP, 2026. DOI: 10.7916/1swr-4871

2021 Gil, Y., et al. (incl. **D. Hardesty Lewis**), "Artificial Intelligence for Modeling Complex Systems: Taming the Complexity of Expert Models to Improve Decision Making". *ACM TiiS*, 2021. DOI: 10.1145/3453172

2019 Garijo, D., et al. (incl. **D. Hardesty Lewis**), "An intelligent interface for integrating climate, hydrology, agriculture, and socioeconomic models". *ACM IUI '19*, 2019. DOI: 10.1145/3308557.3308711

Education

2026 **M.S., Urban Planning**, *Columbia University*, New York City, NY

2017 **B.S., Pure Mathematics**, *University of Texas*, Austin, TX

Key Projects

Predicting Zoning Opposition — Developed the first property- and owner-level causal ML model of NIMBYism: Double Machine Learning (DML) over a 193k case-period panel to isolate the spatial tax of formal protest petitions on allowable building height.

M&A predictor — Built M&A prediction model (Oct.–Dec. 2025) with Prof. Eric Talley on 1.5M Compustat firm-quarters; long-only portfolio beat S&P 500 by 2%/yr (2004–2020), peaking at 6%/yr.

Activities

Sailing — Volunteer Atlantic SAR of the Cheeki Rafiki

Bikepacking — US West & East Coasts

Languages

Spanish — Native Proficiency

French — Professional Working Proficiency

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